

NATHAN SUNDAY

University of Michigan
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EDUCATION

University of Michigan

PhD. Candidate in Economics

2027 (Expected)

Master of Arts in Economics

2024

Makerere University

2019

Master of Arts in Economics

GPA: 4.86/5

Makerere University

2014

Bachelor of Science with Education (Mathematics and Economics)

GPA: 4.74/5

FACULTY ADVISOR

Dean Yang

James Hines

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Public Finance/Economics (Primary)

Development Economics (Secondary)

WORK IN PROGRESS

“Commercial Property Taxes, Firm Behavior, and Fiscal Externalities” [Job Market Paper]

- **Abstract:** *This paper examines the economic effects of commercial property taxes, exploiting a natural experiment in Kampala, Uganda, where a property revaluation and enumeration increased tax liabilities within the city. Using administrative corporate and employee tax data in a difference-in-differences framework, I document four main findings. First, the reform reduced profits, investment, employment, and firm survival. The effects are highly heterogeneous across firms: small firms experience declines in revenue and profits, while larger and financially flexible firms are better able to absorb the shock. Firms also adjust partly through increased wage informality, with some formal job losses reflecting a shift to informal arrangements rather than outright job destruction. Second, the reform had progressive distributional consequences within firms, with workers at the top of the earnings distribution disproportionately affected. Third, the rental cost channel plays an important role in transmitting property tax burdens to firms, with an estimated pass-through rate to formal tenant firms of 0.53. Finally, I quantify a vertical fiscal externality whereby each UGX 1 increase in local property tax revenue reduces central government income tax revenue by approximately UGX 0.26. Using the Marginal Value of Public Funds framework, I estimate that each UGX 1 of net consolidated revenue cost the public UGX 1.43, implying that the reform is welfare-improving only if the public goods it finances exceed this threshold in value.*

“Old-Age Pension and Labor Market Outcomes of Younger Individuals: Evidence from Uganda”

- **Summary:** *This paper examines whether non-contributory old-age pension programs have spillover effects on labor market outcomes of ineligible adults in the household.*
- Awarded the prize for **Outstanding Third Year Paper**, 2024, Department of Economics, University of Michigan

“The Economic and Fiscal Effects of Decentralization: Evidence from Uganda”

- **Summary:** *This paper examines whether decentralization of governance generates tangible gains for the private sector and how it affects fiscal capacity, using administrative tax data from Uganda.*

SELECTED PRE-DOCTORAL PUBLICATIONS

“Does Corruption Explain the Decision to Invest and the Value of Investment? Revisiting Evidence from Sub-Saharan African Firms” (with Ibrahim Mike Okumu and Edward Bbaale), *Journal of International Development*, October 2025.

“Gender of a Manager and Firm Performance in Africa: Does the Business Environment Play a Moderating Role?” (with Ibrahim Okumu and Edward Bbaale), *Journal of International Development*, Vol. 36, No. 8, November 2024, pp. 3082–3124.

“How Specific Resilience Pillars Mitigate the Impact of Drought on Food Security: Evidence from Uganda” (with Rehema Kahunde, Blessing Atwine, Adesoji Adelaja, and Justin George), *Food Security*, Vol. 15, No. 1, September 2022, pp. 111-131(2023)

SELECTED BLOGS, POLICY BRIEFS, OPINION ARTICLES

“Impact of COVID-19 on Micro, Small, and Medium Businesses in Uganda” (blog with Paul Lakuma), *Brookings, Focus in Africa*, May 2020. [Link to the Article](#)

“The **Uganda Business Climate Index (BCI)**, between 2019 and 2021 (Co-authored)”. Some of the BCI reports can be found at the following links: [\[BCI, March 2019\]](#); [\[BCI, Sept 2019\]](#); [\[BCI, Dec 2019\]](#); [\[BCI, March 2020\]](#); [\[BCI, May 2020\]](#); [\[BCI, June 2020\]](#); [\[BCI, Dec 2020\]](#); [\[BCI, March 2021, Special Issue\]](#); [\[BCI, March 2021\]](#); [\[BCI, Aug 2021, Special Issue\]](#).

“A Rapid Assessment of the Effect of the COVID-19 Lockdown on Livelihoods and Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises in Uganda” (with Francis Mwesigye, Tony Odokonyero, and Mildred Barungi), *Economic Policy Research Centre*, Policy Note: 8, August 2021. [Link to the Report](#)

AWARDS AND SCHOLARSHIPS

Graduate Research Award, Department of Economics, University of Michigan, \$3,000. 2025

Doctoral Research Grant, Rackham Graduate School, University of Michigan, \$3,000. 2025

Outstanding Third Year Paper Award, 2024, Department of Economics, University of Michigan
Paper: Old-Age Pension and Labor Market Outcomes of Younger Individuals: Evidence from Uganda.

Structural Transformation of Agriculture and Rural Spaces (STARS) Fellowship Program, Cornell University, International Food Policy Research Institute, and Michigan State University. 2020

Thematic Research Grant (US\$ 11,000), African Economic Research Consortium. 2019 - 2020
Paper: “Gender of a manager and firm performance in Africa: Does the business environment play a moderating role”.

Scholarship for Masters degree, African Economic Research Consortium (AERC). 2016 - 2018

Undergraduate scholarship, Government of Uganda. 2011 - 2014

HONORS AND PERSONAL ACHIEVEMENTS

Best student, Master of Arts in Economics, Makerere University 2019

Overall best student, AERC Collaborative Masters Programme (CMAP) 2017

Best student, College of Education and External Studies, Makerere University 2014

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

2024: 6th World Bank/IFS/ODI Public Finance Conference, Washington DC

2019: African Economic Research Consortium (AERC) Bi-Annual Research Workshop, Nairobi, Kenya

PROFESSIONAL WORK EXPERIENCE

PhD Fellow, National Planning Authority, Uganda May - Aug 2024

Research Analyst, Economic Policy Research Centre, Uganda 2019 - 2021

Labor Support Officer, Research Unit, Ministry of Gender, Labor & Social Development, Uganda 2018 - 2019

SKILLS

Languages: English (Proficient)

Software: Stata (Advanced), R (Intermediate), LaTeX (Advanced), MatLab (Intermediate)

OTHERS

Citizenship: Citizen of Uganda (F-1 Visa)